

everything a router does but instead of having an Ethernet, (RJ45), WAN port it has an RJ11 WAN port. Additionally, an ADSL router will also have a built in modem. In fact, such routers are often referred to as DSL modems. If you are opting for a new internet connection you should make sure exactly what interface your ISP will provide. In case a regular Ethernet connection is provided, you cannot use an ADSL router for your internet connection. We tested five ADSL routers across Dlink, Netgear and Linksys.

Features

Linksys' design on both their routers was attractive and very space age-like. Since your router is likely to be placed on a table or mounted on a wall we figure looks should warrant at least a cursory mention. The WAG160N looks futuristic with a square appearance with no sharp corners. The outer bezel is higher and the centre portion gently bulges. The centre is finished in piano black and the outer bezel is gun grey. The design has no external antennas. All activity LEDs are embedded in the black bezel and icons of the indicators are clearly visible that speaks of a top quality product. The LEDs green aren't intrusive. The WAG54G2 is entirely black although the finish is matte and not glossy. Netgears DGN2000 also looks neat with its rounded design. Build quality is top class. Both the WAG160N and the DGN2000 are Draft N routers and the WAG160N supports MIMO technology that helps throughput by improving spectral efficiency or the ability to transfer more bits per available hertz of wireless bandwidth. The other routers were based on the slower 802.11G specification. There is also a stark difference in the price and the Draft N

ADSL routers cost more than double some of the others. The Netgear DGN2000 has a power button on the rear which many routers don't have. There are also a couple of buttons

on the side, one to toggle Wi-Fi on and off which is very useful

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Dlink DSL-2640T

and the other to enable WPS, a security feature. The Netgear DS834G was built around the same lines as the DGN2000, but it's a glossy white finish instead of black. Interestingly, Netgear provided a couple of feet for this router so it can stand by itself, no such paraphernalia with the DGN2000 which is weird because we found the signal to be stronger when the device is standing up instead of lying flat on the table. The Netgear DS834G misses a few options in the firmware. Under Wireless Settings, you can only select between B and G modes. There are no speed settings available that nearly every other router/ADSL router had. The firewall section is very easy and intuitive and there is a simple option available to block IM ports. There is no option for conditional blocking of IPs.

Performance

We expected the Draft N routers to be speed demons and they were. Since this new

specification is some time away from finalisation nobody knows for sure which of the Draft N devices will fully comply with the final specifications. For your information IEEE will decide the final specification for Draft N sometime later this year.

The real world transfer tests were what we most closely monitored and the random file transfer was of special interest because it stresses the device.

The Netgear DGN2000 is by far the fastest device in this segment and it was the only device to transfer more than 1 MBps in zone 3.

Surprisingly in zone 1 it also had the lowest signal strength (80%) and still managed a whopping 4 MBps which is pretty good. The Linksys WAG160N is the second fastest device, but it trails by a huge margin. The Dlink DSL-2640T is also pretty decent and for an 802.11G device, gets pretty close to the DGN2000. Interestingly, none of these devices are really suitable for streaming video content so multimedia junkies will want to look elsewhere. The Netgear DGN2000 does manage well with DVD videos, but 1080p content proves a bit too much to handle, especially in zone 2 and 3.

Conclusion

Since these zones are more indicative of a

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Netgear DGN2000

household scenario (it's unlikely the router will be placed in the same room as all the clients) we don't recommend anyone looking to stream videos wirelessly waste his time here. The Netgear DGN2000 is wonderfully fast at transfers but it's also quite expensive at Rs. 8,260. The Linksys WAG160N is equally costly but much slower and so totally loses out. The Dlink DSL-2640T is what we recommend for budget users who need an ADSL router and it wins our Best Buy award. If you must buy ADSL for speed, get the DGN2000 – the best performing ADSL router. If you don't need the RJ11 connectivity, consider buying a non-ADSL router.

Routers

A lot of ISPs provide Ethernet connectivity for the internet. A wireless router can also function as an access point if need be. Since all wireless routers (including ADSL routers) have at least four LAN ports they can be used as a wired LAN, a wireless only LAN or a mixed (wired and wireless) network. Their WAN port is RJ45 and they can serve the functions of a router to both wired and wireless clients. There were big names from the 18 wireless routers we tested; these included Belkin, Linksys, Netgear, Dlink, Senao, Buffalo, Apple and Compex. The price range was as diverse, the cheapest router was an uber-affordable Rs. 1,990 while the costliest router weighed in at Rs. 10,999. For the purpose of comparison and awards we divided this category into two parts, routers up to Rs. 5,000 and those above Rs. 5,000.

Features

Some routers were beauties – works of art with great care taken in their sculpting and design. Apple's Airport Extreme 802.11 N was built like a tank. This pure white square shaped router had rounded edges and